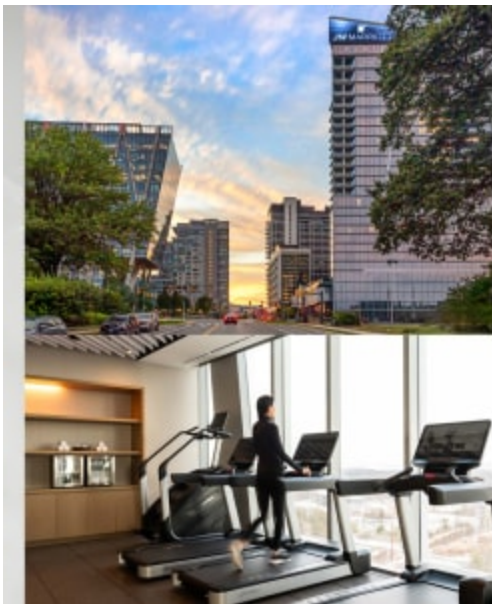


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News

UPDATED: Coffey, Cunningham win County Board primary

By **ARLnow.com**

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People watch the results of the ranked-choice tabulation on Friday, June 23, 2023 in Courthouse (staff photo by Jay Westcott)

(Updated at 9:40 a.m. on 6/26/23) The ballots have all been counted and the results are finalized: [Maureen Coffey](#) and [Susan Cunningham](#) are the Democratic nominees for the Arlington County Board.

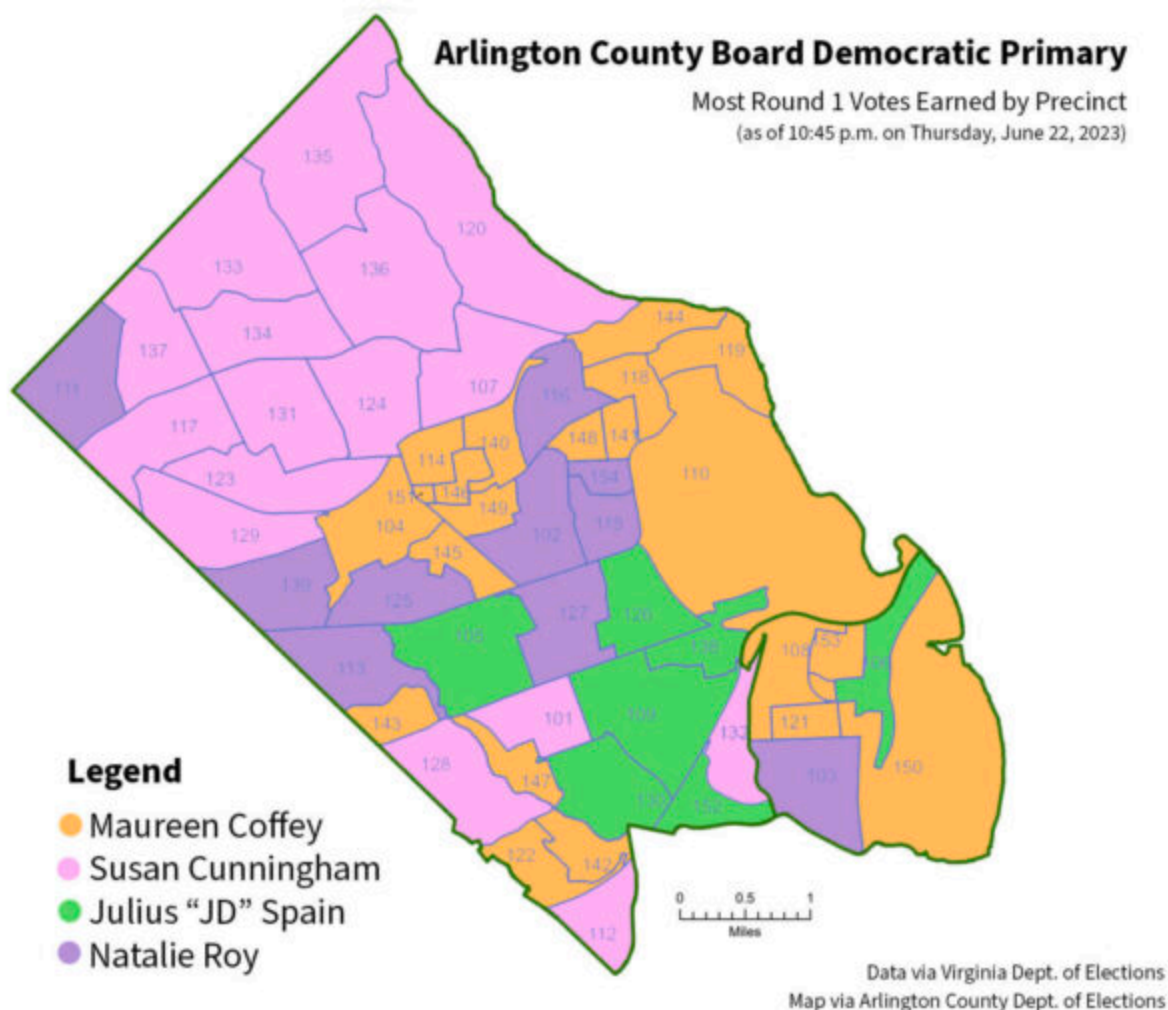
The results, released at 3:15 p.m. today (Saturday), culminated Arlington's trial run of [ranked-choice voting method](#). Eyes across the state were reportedly on Arlington, which the state legislature allowed to use the process for County Board elections one year before extending the right to the rest of the Commonwealth.

At noon today, Arlington election officials adjudicated the remaining 135 provisional ballots and began tabulating them around 1 p.m. These ballots were not expected to change the outcome of the tabulation yesterday (Friday), when officials processed ballots from early voting, [primary day voting](#), and mail-in ballots.

On Tuesday's primary day, no candidate in the six-way race crossed the threshold with only the first round of votes counted. Arlington waited until all the ballots were in, save provisional ballots, before eliminating lower vote-getters and tallying second- and third-place rankings.

Coffey, a researcher for the think tank American Progress, appears to have captured votes from many millennial renters like herself, receiving 10,786 votes.

Cunningham, who ran an unsuccessful bid for Arlington County Board [as an independent](#) in 2020, received 14,208 votes, initially carried by several precincts north of Langston Blvd.



Arlington County Board Democratic Primary Round 1 votes by precinct (by Jo DeVoe)

Coffey emerged victorious in the fourth round, after Jonathan Dromgoole, Tony Weaver and Julius "JD" Spain were eliminated, in that order. Cunningham crossed the victory

threshold in round six, after Natalie Roy was eliminated.

Member County Board (Arlington County)

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(Vote for not more than two)

Ranked Choice Contest

Candidate	Round 1	Round 2	Round 3	Round 4	Round 5	Round 6	Round 7
Maureen E. Coffey Winner	22% 6,298 votes	24% 6,640 votes +342	25% 7,051 votes +411	40% 10,727 votes +3,676			
Susan R. Cunningham Winner	25% 6,935 votes	25% 7,055 votes +120	27% 7,440 votes +385	31% 8,540 votes +1,100	34% 8,846 votes +306	60% 14,164 votes +5,318	
Natalie U. Roy	24% 6,699 votes	24% 6,827 votes +128	25% 7,089 votes +262	29% 7,885 votes +796	31% 8,104 votes +219	x Eliminated	
Julius D. "JD" Spain, Sr.	20% 5,549 votes	21% 5,908 votes +359	23% 6,295 votes +387	x Eliminated			
G. O. "Tony" Weaver	5% 1,440 votes	6% 1,550 votes +110	x Eliminated				
Jonathan Dromgoole	4% 1,090 votes	x Eliminated					

How the ranking rounds played out for Arlington County Board (via Virginia Dept. of Elections)

Tabulation yesterday and today at county government headquarters was open to the public as was the certification of the results.

Both Coffey and Cunningham were both present on Friday. Coffey observed the vibe in the tabulation room was upbeat, complimenting Director of Elections Gretchen Reinemeyer for walking through every step, even though it seemed boring and technical.

“But as we waited for each step to happen, people were joking and laughing and being silly with it,” she said. “I think it’s reflective, Arlington County has some really good people.”

After the preliminary results were finalized on Friday, Coffey seemed stunned.

“This is so surreal,” she said. “This is wild.”

Cunningham was similarly upbeat.

“I am just excited at the prospect of serving our community next January,” Cunningham told ARLnow shortly after the tabulation. “I’m ready to take a true deep breath and I’m really proud of our candidates and the community for having a good and clean race.”

Spain, the former head of the Arlington NAACP who was seen by many insiders as a likely nominee, conceded the race around 6:30 p.m. on Friday.

“A short time ago, I spoke with both [Coffey] and [Cunningham] via a three-way phone call to congratulate them for winning the Democratic nomination for Arlington County Board,” he said via Twitter. “I wish them the best of success in preparing for the November general election and taking up the responsibilities of public office. This is their moment to reflect and rejoice. ”

[Recent zoning changes](#) took center stage during the campaign. Spain and Coffey expressed support for the Missing Middle housing initiative, while Roy and Cunningham were generally opposed.

There was some overlap, however, for the two victors. Cunningham said Missing Middle was an example of how the county needed to take more time to get housing right. Coffey criticized the county for not demonstrating how Missing Middle, which she admitted was not a silver bullet, fits into its broader plans to make housing attainable to residents.

As the Democratic nominees, Coffey and Cunningham will face at least one opponent in the November general election. Perennial independent candidate Audrey Clement has qualified for the County Board ballot, while a Republican, [Juan Carlos Fierro](#), has his ballot qualification “in process,” according to the Arlington County [election website](#).

Clement [expressed vocal opposition](#) to Missing Middle in her unsuccessful bid for County Board last year.

Coffey says she will be knocking on more doors heading into November.

“There are places that turned out to support me and that’s wonderful and there are places that turned out for other candidates,” she said. “I want to make sure I have a conversation with them and hear about their concerns and what’s on their minds. This is about being on the County Board for all of Arlington not just the places that supported me.”

Jo DeVoe and Jay Westcott contributed to this report